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Newsom Signs Bill Addressing Hate Crimes

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California Governor Gavin Newsom, a Democrat, signed a bill into law on October 8 addressing the rise of hate crimes in the state.

The bill, Assembly Bill 57, states that the California State Auditor concluded that law enforcement has not adequately identified and responded to the rise in hate crimes in the state since 2014. The number of hate crimes in the state was 1,015 in 2019, a decrease from 2018 but still higher than it was in 2014 (758). The bill also notes that hate crimes against the Asian American and Pacific Islander (AAPI) community have soared since 2019 and 2020 as a result of the COVID-19 pandemic.

To address the rise in hate crimes, the bill urges law enforcement to develop better guidelines on the matter based on recommendations from various experts.

"The recent violence against the Asian American and Jewish communities is unacceptable and demands a firm response from every level of government," Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Woodland Hills), who authored the bill and heads the California Legislative Jewish Caucus, said in a statement. "At this moment, when so many in our state are feeling vulnerable, we must do more to protect those who are targeted by hate. Our legislation will significantly strengthen law enforcement training and coordination to ensure that California is better prepared to address hate crimes and protect vulnerable communities."

Allison Gold, who chairs the Jewish Public Affairs Committee (JPAC), said in a statement that JPAC supports the bill because it "will significantly impact the rise in hate crimes and strengthen our State's response to effectively combat it."

Nancy Appel, who heads the Anti-Defamation League's California chapter, told The Jewish News of Northern California (the J) that the bill is "a major piece in the overall fight against hate crime."

The bill passed through both Houses of the state legislature on September 8 and 9 and is a piece of a larger coalition of bills in the legislature addressing hate crimes.

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